Wer hat dies Liedlein erdacht?

Who invented this little song?

Gustav Mahler (1860–1911)

Background

Gustav Mahler was born into a Jewish family in Kalischt (in the Austrian Empire at the time, and now in the Czech Republic). Facing the pressures and prejudices of anti-semitism throughout his life, he converted to Catholicism in order to help his career. He was to become a leading conductor (Vienna Opera, Metropolitan Opera – New York) and composer, primarily of Lieder and symphonies. Indeed, he often combined the two genres with orchestral settings of songs such as the cycle *Das Lied von der Erde* (The song of the earth), or incorporating song material into his symphonies. The collection of some seven hundred folk poems *Das Knaben Wunderhorn* (The Youth's Magic Horn) – subtitled 'Old German Songs' – caught the young Mahler's imagination from an early age. He embarked on composing a series of settings for voice and piano or orchestra, and the influence of these poems was to continue into his early symphonies and for many years afterwards. This song was written in 1892 and is typical of Mahler's attraction to the humour and simplicity of such folk poems.

Idiomatic translation

There, high on the mountain, stands a house.
A fine, lovely maid looks out from it.
That is not her home,
She is the innkeeper's daughter.
She lives on the green heath.

My heart is sick!
Come, my darling, and cure it.
Your dark brown eyes
Have wounded me.

Your rosy lips
Can cure sick hearts,
Make young men sensible,
Make dead men alive,
Can cure the sick.

Who made up this lovely little song?
Three geese brought it across the water.
Two grey ones and a white one;
And for those who can't sing this song,
They will whistle it to them. Yes!

Pronunciation – Wer hat dies Liedlein erdacht? [veːʁ hat diːs liːtlain ɛʁdaxt]

Dort oben am Berg in dem hohen Haus!
dɔrt |oːbən |am bɛrk |ɪn deːm hoːən haus

Da gukket ein fein's, lieb's Mädel heraus.
da kʊkət |ain fains liːbs mɛːdəl hɛraus

Es ist nicht dort daheime!
|ɛs |ɪst nɪçt dɔrt dahaimə

Es ist des Wirts sein Töchterlein!
|ɛs |ɪst dɛs vɪrts zain tœçtɐlain

Es wohnet auf grüner Heide!
|ɛs voːnət |auf gryːnɐ haidə

Mein Herzle ist wund!
main hɛrtslə |ɪst vʊnt

Komm, Schätzle, mach's g'sund!
kɔm ʃɛtslə maxs kʊnt

Dein' schwarzbraune Äuglein,
dain ʃvartsbraunə |ɔiglain

die hab'n mich verwund't!
diː habn mɪç fɛɐvʊndt

Dein rosiger Mund
dain roːzɪgɐ mʊnt

macht Herzen gesund.
maxt hɛrtsən gəzʊnt

Macht Jugend verständig,
maxt juːgənt fɛɐʃtendɪç

macht Tote lebendig,
maxt toːtə lebɛndɪç

macht Kranke gesund, ja, gesund.
maxt krankə gəzʊnt ja gəzʊnt

Wer hat denn das schön schöne Liedlein erdacht?
veːɐ hat dɛn das ʃøːn ʃøːnə liːtlain |ɛɐdaxt

Es haben's drei Gäns' übers Wasser gebracht.
|ɛs habəns drai gens |yːbɛs vasɐ gəbraxt

Zwei graue und eine weiße!
tsvai grauə |ʊnt |ainə vaisə

Und wer das Liedlein nicht singen kann,
|ʊnt veːɐ das liːtlain nɪçt zɪŋən kan

dem wollen sie es pfeifen! Ja.
deːm vɔlən ziː |ɛs pfaifən ja

Further notes

Note the pronunciation of **g'sund** [ksʊnt] and **gukket** [kʊkət] which are colloquial expressions in Southern Germany.

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CD1 spoken text / piano accompaniment

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(1860–1911)

Des Knaben Wunderhorn
(The Youth's Magic Horn)

Mit heiterem Behagen *(with easy gaiety)* [♩. = 54]



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